

RupeeRise
Designing for safe financial behaviour, not just financial knowledge
Timeline: 14-day hackathon (parallel to full-time role)
Role: Lead Product Designer (UX, UI, Product Thinking)
Platform: Mobile-first application

1. Context

The hackathon brief focused on improving financial literacy among teenagers and young earners.
The initial assumption was that users lacked financial knowledge, and that better tracking and education could solve the problem.
However, during exploration, it became clear that exposure to financial tools had increased significantly. Many users already had access to investing apps and financial content.
The challenge was not access.
It was behaviour.

2. Refined Problem

Young earners:

- Are exposed to investing early
- Are influenced by short-term gain narratives
- Often feel anxious or overconfident
- Lack structured progression before risking real money

The real gap was not information.
It was the absence of behavioural guardrails.

RupeeRise therefore focused on:
Helping users develop stable financial behaviour before increasing exposure to risk.
Financial literacy remained important — but as a supporting layer, not the end goal.

3. Constraints

- 14-day timeline
- Research conducted during weekday evenings
- Design and prototyping over weekends
- Lightweight but focused validation

Given the time constraint, the goal was not scale validation, but clarity of direction and responsible system design.

4. Research Snapshot

Primary Inputs

- Informal interviews with early earners and young professionals
- Discussions around spending anxiety, credit usage, and investing hesitation

Secondary Inputs

- Review of Indian fintech and investing platforms
- Analysis of finfluencer content and beginner investing journeys

Key Observations

- Users fear irreversible financial loss.
- Financial dashboards often increase anxiety instead of clarity.
- Beginners either avoid investing completely or jump in impulsively.
- Consistency matters more than feature depth.

These observations shaped the behavioural focus of the product.

5. Core Metric

The core metric for RupeeRise is:
Behavioural progression toward stable financial decision-making.
This includes:

- Consistent tracking habits
- Completion of learning modules
- Simulation engagement before real exposure
- Gradual, controlled increase in investment limits

Success is defined by behavioural maturity, not transaction volume.

6. Product Structure — Four Supporting Pillars

The system was designed around four connected pillars.

❑ Behaviour Awareness

Tracking is included not as a generic feature, but as a behavioural signal layer.

It:

- Identifies discretionary spending patterns
- Supports budget awareness
- Enables context-based nudges

Purpose:

Ensure investment decisions are grounded in real financial capacity.

❑ Structured Learning

Learning modules simplify key financial concepts and validate understanding through short quizzes.

Learning acts as:

- Confidence building
- Progress gating
- Preparation for exposure

Purpose:

Knowledge as readiness, not as isolated content.

❑ Simulation Before Capital

All users begin with simulation using real market data.

Why:

- Experience volatility safely
- Understand price movement emotionally
- Reduce fear before committing capital

Simulation is mandatory in early stages and adaptive in mature stages.

Purpose:

Practice before risk.

❑ Adaptive Guardrails

The system adjusts friction based on behavioural maturity:

- Guarded Mode (higher friction, strict caps)
- Guided Mode (moderate friction)
- Autonomous Mode (lower friction, critical alerts remain active)

If risky patterns re-emerge, friction is gradually reintroduced.

Purpose:

Encourage independence without removing safety.

7. Interaction Philosophy

Primary tone: Calming

Secondary: Stabilising

Tertiary: Light gamification

Design choices reflect this:

- Progress-first home screen
- Clear hierarchy
- Limited colour emphasis
- No urgency-based notifications

The product intentionally avoids stimulation-driven engagement.

8. Monetization Consideration (Long-Term)

If scaled, monetization would align with behavioural safety:

- Mentor sessions
- Advanced analytics
- Goal-aligned financial partnerships

High-risk asset promotion or impulse-driven advertising would contradict the system’s philosophy and are intentionally excluded.

9. Validation & Feedback

During the hackathon:

- Users responded positively to the simulation-first approach.
- Progress framing felt less stressful than balance-heavy dashboards.
- Jury feedback acknowledged the responsible structure and system-level thinking, while noting the need for long-term validation to measure sustained behavioural change.

Given the time constraint, long-term behavioural measurement was outside scope.

10. Reflection

RupeeRise began as a financial literacy concept.

It evolved into a behaviour-first financial system.

The key learning was that:

Designing for financial behaviour requires balancing autonomy and guardrails.
Reducing risk is not about restricting users permanently, but about guiding them toward stable independence.